> undue force; and to submit a monthly statement describing the condition of the people, the state of public security, the range of market prices and rents, the conditions of the poor and all other contingencies.

As we have seen, the revenue system was based on the division of the empire into provinces, or subahs, which were administered by a governor, later known as the subedar. The governor controlled the largest body of troops in the area and was responsible for keeping the peace. The subahs were further divided into sarkars, or districts, which were the real administrative units of the land, and had a military commander, a faujdar, assigned to them. The revenue-collecting work in the sarkar was carried out by the amalguzar* while kotwals were appointed to all provincial capitals and cities, to maintain order. Some of the lands were owned outright by the state, and were called khalisa land.

The sarkars were made up of parganas, which grouped together the smallest measure of land, the village. Northern Hindustan consisted of tens of thousands of villages, gathered into parganas, from which tax was historically collected using the zamindars, who controlled revenue collection in each pargana. The zamindars were almost always Hindus, and themselves employed a number of cavalrymen and foot retainers, constituting an important semi-military class. ‘Without the support of Hindu agrarian magnates and officials,’ writes Iqtidar Alam Khan, ‘it was now obviously becoming difficult to run a state system.’ Attempts were made to constrain the autonomy of the zamindars, by making them officers of the Mughal state. The land revenue was collected not in crops, but in cash, the copper dam, and this monetized the rural economy.

Because the holders of iqta land had tended to become almost autonomous, extracting tribute from zamindars or farmers exceeding their official grants, Akbar would devise a much more efficient and centralized system in the coming decades for revenue extraction. After more accurate figures on the productivity of land were gathered, a temporary assignment of land revenue from a particular territory, known as a jagir, would be parcelled out to each officer. Later still, as we will see, an integrated decimal hierarchy for top officer administrators—the mansab (rank) system—would be created.